

Win at overcoming technology overload



Jayesh Shinde
Manager – Test Centre
jayesh.shinde@digit.in

"We still struggle to grapple with this always-on, interconnected digital world we've surrounded ourselves in."

For the longest time, we've welcomed technology with open arms in every facet of our complicated lives. From the first television set we operated with a knob to the first arcade console we played 8-bit games on with great aplomb; from brick-like cell phones to the fathomless expanse of the Internet. We've grown up in a world where the digital world has exploded all around us within just over a decade. Some may consider this to be a feat of human ingenuity, a landmark celebrating the progress of our species and collective civilization, but there's no running away from the fact: we still struggle to grapple with this always-on, interconnected digital world we've surrounded ourselves in. While some of us are all at sea trying to exploit and fit into this new reality, others find themselves addicted to digital triggers dictating their life patterns to an overwhelming degree. Technology, and in particular Internet-overload is a reality and it's driving us to the point of no return. I have no doubt that it's a generational issue that we have to resolve, since we created this digital world that we now co-exist in – our kids, who probably will never know what life before the Internet era looked like, will adjust to this digital reality far better than us merely by the virtue and timing of their birth.

I've pretty much grown up with the personal desktop computer and Internet explosion era in India. I remember a time when I used to play football (or soccer) outside with my friends instead of FIFA 2015 with a bunch of online strangers; read traditional books and newspapers more than read for pleasure on my Kindle and consume information on my laptop, tablet and smartphone; meet friends for lunch on weekends rather than just chat with them online or lookup their Facebook feeds. Take my future wife out to cinema halls to watch the monthly blockbuster together rather than entertain ourselves through the contents of a hard drive connected to a laptop or HDTV. And I sure as heck do remember a time when I wasn't a slave to my phone like I'm now, constantly transfixed by it, caught under its vicious spell without any sense of control. This addiction, if you can call it so, was getting so destructive that I would hear phantom phone calls, twitch and tense up every time I heard any phone ring, sit on my arse too long than is good for my health, and invite the

Internet into my life without any checks and balances. Big mistake. Wasn't technology supposed to help and heal? But why blame technology if a certain human is too stupid for his own good?

How does one keep a modicum of sanity into their life and prevent technology and the Internet from becoming a health hazard? It's simple – disconnect. Not once or twice, but from time to time, in a habitual, preordained manner. Recent studies have shown that our over-indulgence with the Internet and an always plugged-in lifestyle is affecting our mental and physical health far worse than our parents or grandparents. More studies have also shown that unplugging ourselves from the digital world and spending uninterrupted, quality time away from our devices boosts our brain's productivity. It's like working Monday to Friday, relaxing on Saturday and Sunday to re-energize, rest, and come ready to focus on work again on the following Monday – the same concept applies with our digital lives to some extent.

That's essentially my New Year's Resolution – to heavily curtail and control the use of technology (and the Internet) in my life. To that effect, I've already started switching off my phones on weekends – unless I want to call someone by choice – and I recommend all of you to give this a shot just to experience the unshackling effect it can have on your life. Making adjustments to my Internet affliction won't be easy, but the tradeoffs are too great (like quality of life, mental well-being, social engagement, etc) to not give it a shot. Especially, entrusted with the responsibility of bringing up our daughter in an overbearingly digital world, I at least want to let her experience, in however small way possible, the world as it is beyond digital marvels. This way, at least she will have a better appreciation of technology in her life than be just hooked on to it without knowing its self-destructive flipside. And avoid or learn from the mistakes of her once digitally challenged father. 

Got feedback about this column?
Drop me a line at:
jayesh.shinde@digit.in